10 Practical Tips for How to Run a Workshop

It's important that everything goes smoothly when you run a workshop to get the most out of the time you spend. You need to be on top of the practicalities if you want your participants to relax and let their creativity loose.

Here are our best tips for how to run efficient workshops:

1. Show up 10 minutes early to prepare, make sure technology works and maybe even set the mood with upbeat music to energize your participants as they arrive.

2. Pause periodically to check for toilet breaks. Water and snacks are a nice touch to keep energy levels high.

3. Set ground rules around using devices so everyone has common expectations and won't be distracted throughout your session.

4. If the group starts to get derailed by off-topic questions or comments, push for progress on your original plan by capturing these points on the whiteboard and come back to them later if you can. Try to address these questions after the workshop if you run out of time.

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5. Nominate someone beforehand to be a documenter for the workshop.

6. It's nice to have someone taking pictures of people in action during the workshop. This kind of documentation is not only a good memento; it can also be a valuable inclusion to a workshop recap you might send out afterward.

7. If you have remote participants, try to use a moveable webcam to make it easier for people on the line to see sketches, Post-its and whiteboards up close. Encourage them to share out their ideas first to make sure they feel included.

8. Spend the last 5 minutes wrapping up to discuss next steps and action items. Thank everyone for their time. This can also be a great chance to ask for feedback on how the session went.

9. Send out a recap to all participants and stakeholders to summarize what you did in your workshop.

10. Add in some photos and artifacts from the session – this keeps the momentum going and helps communicate next steps to the team.

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